fishermen. As the crow flies, it was about 15 km from the main gate of the Mahendragiri integrated test complex. It was ideal for a second launch site.

If launched from here, I calculated, a PSLV would save enough fuel to have a 30% additional payload. This is because we usually spend 30% of fuel to steer the rocket from its eastward path to a southward trajectory. It is called the dogleg manoeuvring. Imagine the tapering end of the Indian peninsula, and you get an idea of how a rocket going straight south from Nagercoil would be better than the one launched from Sriharikota which is some 750 km north. The only negative, if it is considered one, our rockets would then overfly Sri Lanka. But this would not be a problem as the island nation is a friendly country. After all, how many Chinese rockets overfly India without its permission!

I sold the alternative launch site idea to Satish Dhawan. After a preliminary survey, I told Dhawan that we may need just 3,000 acres in and around Irukkanthurai. I met the most influential person in the locality, the priest at the church. When we explained the compensation package for land acquisition, the priest and the community at large were happy. It, however, turned out to be an anticlimax when we took Dhawan to see the place. On our arrival, the villagers garlanded Dhawan and fell at his feet, pleading that they may not be moved out.

I went to the priest who, too, had suddenly had a volte face. Later I learnt that a group doing illicit brewing of liquor in Irukkanthurai had manufactured fear and opposition in the hamlets. But when the friendly priest suddenly turned against the project remains a mystery to me. Whatever be the reason, my plan for an alternative launch site was shelved.

Identifying Mahendragiri for the integrated test complex was not easy, either. I, as the deputy director of the liquid propulsion centre (by then a separate entity at Valiyamala in Trivandrum), and the leader of the Vikas engine project, wanted the facility as close to the liquid propulsion activities in Trivandrum. But, besides the space constraints, several other things proved to be impediments. For one, the high water table Kerala is known for. A leak of UDMH may seep into the water table, geologists told us. The very thought sent shivers down spines.